Mughals were done for.

At the very start, the rana's Afghan commander, Hakim Sur, demolished the Mughal vanguard. These men, along with some eighty-odd skirmishers – called 'chickens of the front line' – 'became hopelessly mixed up together', writes Badauni, in the thorny, uneven ground and the 'twistings of the road'. They 'sustained a complete defeat'. Next, the Mughal left wing, mainly Rajputs, began to fall apart. Rana Pratap came 'charg[ing] out of the pass, and . . . broke through the centre'. A division of Shaikhzadas from Sikri 'all fled at once', followed by Badauni's own battalion.

'Livers grew hot, cries resounded,' writes Abul Fazl, and to those watching it seemed that Mewar would win. Then, all of a sudden, the tide began to turn. Badauni gives some of the credit to an unnamed elephant driver, who fought the rana's legendary elephant, Ram Prasad, an animal Akbar had long coveted. The Mughal mahout led an imperial elephant at Ram Prasad, and 'the two kept charging at one another, until by chance an arrow reached a mortal place in the driver of the Rana's elephant, so that the shock . . . threw him to the ground'.

Rana Pratap began to retreat.

Man Singh, meanwhile, had taken the place of his own mahout, and 'exhibited such intrepidity as surpasses all imagination'. His company of Rajputs, too, got a second wind. Badauni, who had no love lost for his Rajput comrades-in-arms, writes that they 'performed such exploits as were a perfect model'. Indeed, he goes on, Man Singh's leadership exemplified a poet's line: 'A Hindu wields the sword of Islam.'[35]

Abul Fazl tells a different story. According to him, it was at the arrival of the imperial rearguard, and their loud broadcasting of the news that Akbar himself had come to the battlefield, that the enemy, so far 'more and more predominant, lost heart'.

Both historians agree, however, that the Mughal army was too exhausted to pursue its narrowly defeated enemy. It was noon on a summer's day in the desert; Badauni was not exaggerating when he said that it was so hot that 'the very brain boiled in the cranium'. The Mughal troops retreated to Gogunda town nearby, worried about possible night attacks by Mewar, and trying to recover their strength on a diet of meat and mangoes. The latter, eaten 'in default of bread', made many soldiers ill, and besides, writes